It's Great to Be a Cow in World of Warcraft: Forever

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Mulgore has wide skies, **prairie** grass, and the great **plateaus** of Thunder Bluff. It is home to the **tauren**, a race of cow-like people in World of Warcraft. And right now, it is great to be a **tauren**. One **tauren** ability, called Plainsrunning, was almost forgotten. In the original beta, **tauren** did not get mounts at level 40, likely because they were too big and **bulky** to fit on a horse. Instead, they learned Plainsrunning, which let them run as fast as a mount. The idea did not last, and **tauren** were given **kodos** to ride instead. Plainsrunning was forgotten for years. Then it came back in the beta of WoW: Forever. This time, **tauren** slowly built up running speed as they moved, as long as they did not stop or get into combat. Over long distances, it could build up to a nice top speed. Then, after the beta shut down, Blizzard changed something. It boosted Plainsrunning to a cap of a 60-percent movement speed increase. It is as fast as an **apprentice**-level mount, which players do not get until level 40. This is available for **tauren** at level 1. **Tauren** are now zooming across Mulgore, there and gone in a flash. It does take time to build up to 60 percent. **Tauren** get a stack of Plainsrunning every few seconds, and each stack is worth a 2-percent increase, up to a cap of 30 stacks. But in older versions of World of Warcraft, there is a lot of running. Players travel long distances across whole zones and continents. Plainsrunning creeps up to top speed so gradually that it gives players the fun of moving quickly without taking away from that slower pace. You will need a horse to catch this cow.

Word Treasure

plateaus -- Plateaus are large areas of flat land raised high above the land around them.
prairie -- A prairie is a wide, open area of grassland with few trees.
tauren -- Tauren are a race of cow-like people in the game World of Warcraft.
bulky -- Bulky means big and heavy in a way that makes something hard to move or fit.
kodos -- Kodos are big creatures in World of Warcraft that tauren ride like mounts.
apprentice -- An apprentice is a beginner who is still learning a skill.

Background you need

World of Warcraft is a game where players explore a fantasy world as different races, including the tauren, cow-like people who live in Mulgore.

Tauren were once too big and bulky to ride horses, so they were given an ability called Plainsrunning that let them run as fast as a mount instead.

Plainsrunning was forgotten for years, but it returned in WoW: Forever, where tauren build up speed as they keep running until they reach a fast top speed.

That speed lets tauren travel quickly across long distances on foot, which fits a game where players spend a lot of time running between places.

Break it down

LEAD: Tauren in World of Warcraft: Forever can now run as fast as an apprentice-level mount, thanks to the return of the long-forgotten ability Plainsrunning.

KEY EVENT: Blizzard boosted Plainsrunning to a 60-percent movement speed cap after the WoW: Forever beta shut down.

+- WHO: The tauren, a race of cow-like people who live in Mulgore.

+- WHERE: Mulgore, with its wide skies, prairie grass, and the great plateaus of Thunder Bluff.

+- HOW: Tauren gain a stack of Plainsrunning every few seconds while moving, each worth a 2-percent increase, up to a cap of 30 stacks.

+- WHEN: Available at level 1, while an apprentice-level mount is not available until level 40.

BACKGROUND: In the original beta, tauren did not get mounts at level 40 because they were too big and bulky to fit on a horse, so they learned Plainsrunning instead; the idea did not last, and tauren were given kodos to ride.

EVIDENCE: Tauren are now zooming across Mulgore, and the speed builds up so gradually that it keeps the slower pace of older versions of the game while still feeling fun.

OPEN QUESTION: How will the boosted Plainsrunning change the way tauren players travel long distances across zones and continents?

Why it matters

Small design choices like a forgotten running ability can change how a whole game feels to play, and bringing one back shows how game makers listen to what players enjoy. It also shows how an old idea can find new life years later.

Test what you remember

1. Where do the tauren live in World of Warcraft?

- (A) Stormwind
- (B) Mulgore
- (C) Darnassus
- (D) Orgrimmar

2. Why did tauren not get mounts at level 40 in the original beta?

- (A) They were too big and bulky to fit on a horse
- (B) Mounts had not been added to the game yet
- (C) They preferred to walk everywhere
- (D) They had no gold to buy a mount

3. What did Plainsrunning let tauren do in the original beta?

- (A) Teleport between towns
- (B) Run as fast as a mount
- (C) Fly over mountains
- (D) Swim faster than boats

4. How fast can Plainsrunning go after Blizzard changed it?

- (A) A 100-percent movement speed increase
- (B) A 40-percent movement speed increase
- (C) A 60-percent movement speed increase
- (D) A 20-percent movement speed increase

5. How much speed does each stack of Plainsrunning add?

- (A) 1 percent
- (B) 5 percent
- (C) 10 percent
- (D) 2 percent

6. At what level can tauren use Plainsrunning in WoW: Forever?

- (A) Level 40
- (B) Level 1
- (C) Level 10
- (D) Level 20

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: B 4: C 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):